

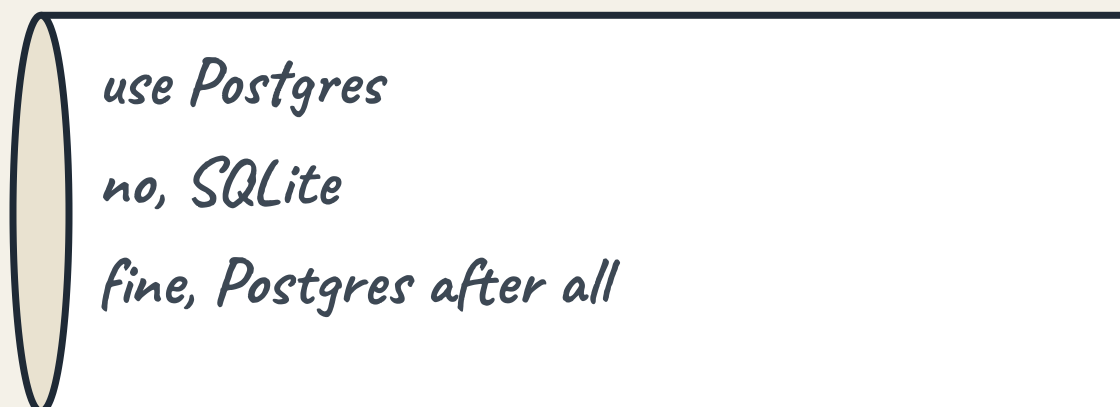
A STORYBOARD IN 6 FRAMES

What has to survive for work to continue



THE HANDOFF

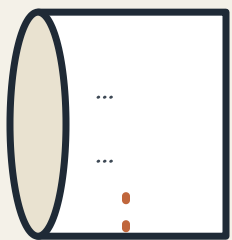
*where it stands,
not how it got here.*



*which one
still stands?*

Continuing work needs what is currently true and an owner for the next step. That's a different problem from keeping a record of how the work got here.

Three questions, not one.



What happened?

the record: evidence, for looking back



Where do things stand?

current truth, for going on



Who owns the next step?

the handoff

One file can serve all three. They're still different jobs. Replay looks back at a past run; continuity keeps enough current truth to go on from here.

A transcript isn't state.

12:02 use Postgres

12:40 no, SQLite

14:15 Postgres after all

14:16 ok

*decided, reversed,
decided again.*

which one governs?

say what's current

CURRENT STATE

database: Postgres

decided 14:15 • next: you

Length isn't the defect. Ambiguity about what's current is. A short transcript can be just as ambiguous as a long one.

Rule, or status?



*Approval is
required before
publishing.*

Instruction

*true for every
piece of work*



*This change is
waiting on
approval.*

(today)

State

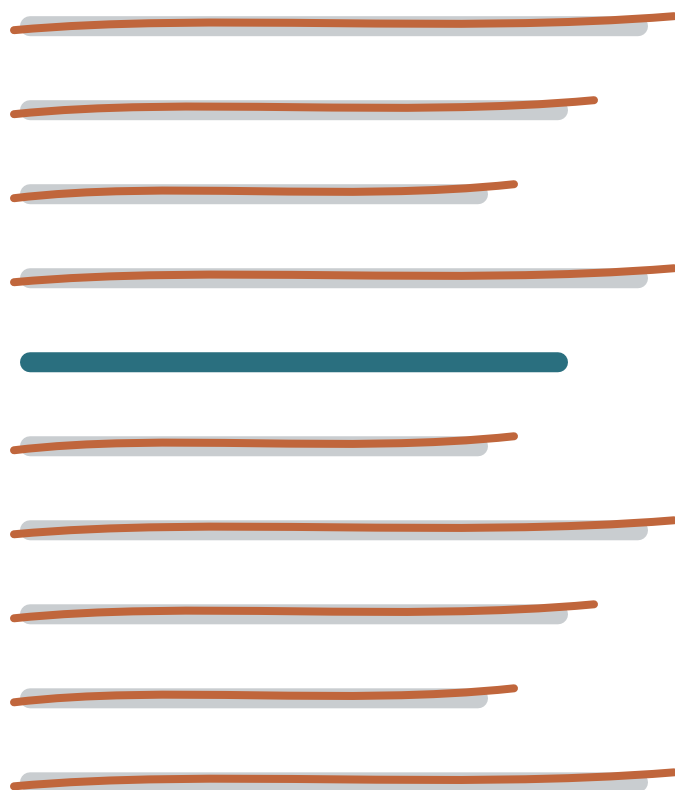
*true this afternoon,
false tomorrow*

Mix them and standing rules get buried in a status note, or live status gets written into the rules, where it quietly stops being true.

“Current” is a label, not a fact.

current.md

Key files touched



35 listed.

34 gone.

true when written.

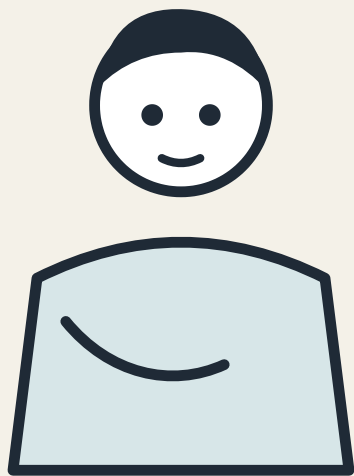
pin the version

date it

name the owner

What a handoff says was true when it was written. Make its position checkable, and re-check the parts that matter before continuing.

Can the next one start without guessing?



- ☒ what's done
- ☒ what's true now
- ☒ the next step
- ☒ constraints still active
- ☒ who owns it

then they can act

A longer record isn't the fix. Separate how the work got here from where it currently stands, and name who owns what happens next.

Read the whole explanation

[pruningmypothos.com/systems/
agent-instructions-and-handoff-as-an-operating-system/](https://pruningmypothos.com/systems/agent-instructions-and-handoff-as-an-operating-system/)

